



Brandon Williams made 51 appearances for Manchester United *The Athletic*

Q&A

Brandon Williams interview: ‘I was immature and stupid. I look back now and think what an idiot I was’



By **Tom Burrows**

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202

“I’ve learned from my mistakes. I take full ownership of everything that’s happened to me. That’s why I always say to myself, ‘I got myself in this mess, I am going to get myself out of it.’”

Sat in the foyer of his Manchester apartment block, Brandon Williams is reflecting on his life in football to date, from the highs of playing 51 times for Manchester United to the dark, lonely moments when he struggled to get out of bed and fell out of love with the game.

Williams admits he is a cautionary tale, a warning of what can happen when a young footballer at one of the world's biggest clubs is thrust into the spotlight with little idea of how to navigate some of the pitfalls that come with that.

That all came to a head when Williams, who admits to having a self-destructive streak, was last year given a 14-month prison sentence, suspended for two years, for dangerous driving after causing a crash while speeding at 99mph.

Yet Williams, who says that incident made him grow up as a person, is now determined to rebuild his football career.

He has spent pre-season training with Rotherham United, who play three leagues below Manchester United, as he tries to work his way back into the sport. The last time he played a full 90 minutes was on loan for Ipswich Town against West Bromwich Albion in November 2023.

He does not yet know whether he will be offered a contract by Rotherham.

"I've let a lot of people down, to be honest, and I want to prove a lot of people wrong as well," he says. "That's one thing that is left to do in my life, to get back onto the football pitch and show what I can do."

In this interview, Williams opens up about his time at Manchester United, when things started to go wrong, his mental struggles and his message to younger players tempted to go down the same path as him.

Before we get there, though, let's rewind to the 2019-20 season at Manchester United — the high point of his career.

Williams, from Harpurhey, a tough suburb of Manchester, is United through and through, having joined his boyhood club aged seven, and worked his way up through the youth teams.

He made his first-team debut in September 2019, a penalty-shootout victory over Rochdale in the EFL Cup.

“It was amazing,” he recalls. “People always ask me, ‘Were you nervous?’. It’s hard to explain unless you experience it yourself. I never felt the pressure or felt worried, it was just excitement and the butterflies were going... because you’re asking me to go on a football pitch, something I’d done for 12 years. It was just about keeping to my game.”

He went on to become a fixture in Ole Gunnar Solskjaer’s side that season, making his Premier League debut against Liverpool in October, and scoring his first United goal the following month.

He was named man of the match in a Europa League victory over Partizan Belgrade in October, with Solskjaer gushing about his performance, [telling reporters](#): “The boy has no fear, he is as brave as a lion and he got us the win.” Around the same time, Ed Woodward, United’s former chief executive, [told friends](#) on a Europa League trip to Astana, Kazakhstan that Williams had become United’s first-choice left-back ahead of Luke Shaw.



Brandon Williams was man of the match in this game against Partizan Belgrade Ash Donelon/Manchester United via Getty Images

For Williams, who was still living with his mum on the council estate in Harpurhey, everything was happening at a dizzying speed.

How did he cope with the attention?

“I found it difficult, especially being from Manchester as well,” he says. “It wasn’t just me who got affected, it was my family as well.”

It was during his breakthrough season at United that the Covid pandemic took hold, halting the football and his momentum.

“It’s funny because we were all on our laptops on Zoom and all the players were in their big mansions with their pools and gyms and I was in my bedroom at my mum’s house, using a suitcase as a dumbbell,” he laughs.

As he was now recognisable on the estate, Williams found it hard to get out for runs without being stopped or mobbed by fans.

When the season finally resumed again in June, he felt his fitness levels had suffered in comparison to his team-mates.

It was around this time he made the decision to move out and live by himself.

“To this day, it’s one of the worst things I’ve ever done,” he says. “I really should have stayed.”

Why?

“I just think as a 19-year-old going to move away from home, playing for United, there’s a lot of things that can go wrong,” he reflects. “I was too immature. I wasn’t aware of a lot of things as well, so I should have stayed with my parents at home to keep that situation under control.”

Because he moved into a bigger house, he says there were regularly people around, which acted as a distraction he now realises was unhealthy.

Williams says his parents — mum Lisa, [who still runs The Snack Attack cafe in Harpurhey](#), and dad Paul, a window-fitter — helped to keep him grounded.

The following season, Williams found opportunities harder to come by and was limited to just 14 appearances, making only five starts.

Falling down the pecking order at United, he moved on loan to Norwich City, who were then in the Premier League, for 2021-22. Although he found it a tough adjustment living more than four hours away from home, he was grateful for the chance to play regular first-team football.

When Williams returned to United, he did so with an injury and a new manager in Erik ten Hag. He went on to play just five minutes that entire season.

The defender struggled with that feeling of being left out of the squad entirely.

“The difficulty is when you’re not being told anything and you’re just in the dark,” he says. “You’re just a passenger at that point.”

However, it seemed there might be a reprieve going into the 2023-24 season when he featured in United’s pre-season matches in the United States. “But when I got back, I just wasn’t involved in anything, so I was like, ‘what is going on here?’” he adds.

Eager to play again, Williams linked up with Kieran McKenna for a loan move to Ipswich Town, working with a coach he knew well from his time at United. It started brightly, with Williams believing he was playing his best football since 2019-20.

“Then a lot of stuff happened in the October-November time,” he says. “Kieran could see that I wasn’t myself. On the New Year’s Day game, we had Stoke away. He said, ‘I want you to go to Manchester and have two weeks off. I want you to come back down here as Brandon, I don’t want to see *this* Brandon’. I was like, ‘OK, no problem’.”



Brandon Williams' time at Ipswich Town did not end well Alex Pantling/Getty Images

However, while Ipswich went on to win promotion to the Premier League that season, Williams played no further part — remaining in Manchester as his off-field issues escalated, which included some problems with friends.

Recalling that time, Williams says he was speaking with psychologist Michael Farrell, who he knew from his time in United's academy.

“He would come and knock on my door in the morning, because I had an apartment in town, and he’d be like, ‘Brandon, come on, we’re going to get a coffee’, because I’d literally just be in bed all day. It helped me have that to get up and be like, ‘Come on, stop feeling sorry for yourself.’” Williams also cites the support of friends, including those he played with in United’s academy, who rallied around to help during that tough time.

It was during that summer of 2024 that Williams was released by United at the end of his contract, ending a 16-year association with the club.

How did that feel?

“At the time I was just like, ‘Whatever, it is what it is’, but I was in a dark space,” he says. “And then a couple of months passed and I was thinking, ‘Oh my god, what have I done?’. Then it hit me that was what I’d known all my life from seven years of age. It was a gutting feeling, especially when you are by yourself and you’re just thinking about it. It’s a dark place.”

It was during this low period that Williams fell out of love with football.

“I didn’t want to play football again,” he says. “It was difficult but I just knew I had to go and train for my mental side of things — I knew I had to do something. I had no plans on going back to football for that whole year. It went on until the start of the new year that I was like, ‘Right, I miss this now, I’m ready to go back, I am ready to get back into football’.”

Away from the pitch, [Williams’ problems were mounting](#).

In May last year, he was given that suspended prison sentence and ordered to complete 180 hours of community service after pleading guilty to dangerous driving. He was also handed a three-year driving ban.

[The Crown Prosecution Service said](#) Williams, who was with a female passenger, was driving at up to 99mph in a 70mph zone in his Audi A3, with a balloon at his mouth, during the incident on August 20, 2023. He then collided with a Ford Fiesta and crashed into the central reservation.

How does he reflect on that?

“It made me grow up as a person and realise that this is real life, this isn’t GTA (Grand Theft Auto) or something like that,” Williams replies. “It was a proper wake-up call. Since then it was about building and changing a reputation that I had and that’s not me.”

Williams says the crash happened at a time when he was in a self-destructive mode, when he was not thinking about the consequences of his actions.

“I wasn’t the Brandon that everyone knows,” he adds. “I was a completely different person.”

During the hearing, Williams’ defence lawyer, Richard Littler KC, explained how the footballer described himself as someone “who had little guidance on the pitfalls of being a young, high-earning footballer”.

Asked to elaborate on that, Williams replies: “It does put a lot on you — there are not many people who have done what I’ve done, so it is difficult. You’re at a club that’s worldwide but you feel very lonely sometimes and it’s difficult to navigate what’s right from wrong, especially at that age, because you’ve got the freedom to do whatever you want.”

Williams hopes his case acts as a warning to others.



Brandon Williams hopes other players can learn from his mistakes George Wood/Getty Images

As he reflects, he feels there was not enough support in place for young footballers. He suggests young players at big clubs should do some form of business education alongside their football for several years, or be made to set aside a certain amount of their earnings that they cannot access until they turn 21. He also believes it would be beneficial for young players to speak with a former player from the same club who had been through similar experiences.

“I was 19, I was like, ‘I know what I’m doing’, but I was immature and stupid,” he says.

Williams found it hard to trust people, as he feared they might take advantage of him.

He remembers signing a four-year contract with United in August 2020, on greatly enhanced terms.

“Even my family had not seen that (money) before, so then it’s difficult even for them to navigate. It was like, ‘What do we do?’. They were in the same boat as me. And then it’s just easy to p**s it all up the wall.”

Another issue raised during the hearing was nitrous oxide, otherwise known as laughing gas. As [The Athletic previously reported](#), the court heard that while Williams had a balloon in his mouth and had used nitrous oxide in the past, he was not using it in the moments before the collision.

Williams says he regrets taking laughing gas in the past.

“I look back at myself now and think what an idiot I was. That is not what an athlete does, it’s not what a footballer does, it’s not what a grown man does. It’s stupid stuff.”

He explains how his use of laughing gas, now a Class C drug — that would not show up in a footballer’s drug testing — was a form of escapism.

“It makes everything 10 times worse, but you don’t realise that when you’re doing it at the time,” he says.

He wants to warn others about its dangers.

“I’ve seen people who can’t walk anymore,” he says. “And that just takes one of them (one balloon), it’s horrible.”

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Brandon Williams and a case that highlights football's laughing gas issue

Nitrous oxide - or laughing gas - has been used by some footballers in recent years but it is now a banned substance in the UK

Now, though, Williams, who is in a new and settled relationship, is looking forward again. Injury meant he made only one appearance for Hull City last season, but he enjoyed his time there.

He is driven by a desire to make his family proud.

“My Nan is on at me because she’s got a frame where it’s me playing at 18, 19, 20 and 21,” he explains. “Every time I go and see her, she points at it and says, ‘I want you to be doing that again’. That’s my motivation.”

Williams, who is 25, is now able to look back on his time with United and feel a sense of achievement — and enjoys regaling people with tales about the “wizard” Juan Mata in training and the “absolutely unreal” Paul Pogba.

“I’ve only just started to look back and be like, ‘I actually did something. I actually played for United 51 times’. It’s something to be proud of,” he says.

He is still in contact with the likes of Harry Maguire, Marcus Rashford and Bruno Fernandes.

He explains how Fernandes still checks in on him and is happy to sort him out with match tickets. “That’s why he’s the captain, he’s an unreal guy.”

Williams is now determined to resurrect his football career.

“I know it’s not going to be a quick process, I know I’m not going to be in the Premier League next year,” he says. “I’m ready to climb the mountain and get back to the top of it.”

Tom Burrows is a football news reporter for The Athletic UK, based in London. He was previously a staff editor for three years. Before that, he worked on news and investigations for national newspapers.

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